

Descartes on the Limits of Automata

Discourse on the Method, from Part V

RENÉ DESCARTES (1596–1650)

SOURCE. *Discourse on the Method*, originally published 1637. Translation by Elizabeth S. Haldane and G. R. T. Ross, 1911.

NOTE. Paragraph breaks, marked ►, added by the editor.

CONTEXT. Descartes has just argued that the bodies of humans and animals are, in effect, machines. This raises a question: could a machine made to look and act like us be told apart from a real human being?

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- And this will not seem strange | to those, who, knowing how many different *au-* 115 | 116
tomata or moving machines can be made by the industry of man, without employ-
ing in so doing more than a very few parts in comparison with the great multitude
of bones, muscles, nerves, arteries, veins, or other parts that are found in the body
of each animal. From this aspect the body is regarded as a machine which, having
been made by the hands of God, is incomparably better arranged, and possesses in
itself movements which are much more admirable, than any of those which can be
invented by man.
- Here I specially stopped to show that if there had been such machines, possessing
the organs and outward form of a monkey or some other animal without reason, we
should not have had any means of ascertaining that they were not of the same nature
as those animals.
- On the other hand, if there were machines which bore a resemblance to our body and
imitated our actions as far as it was morally possible to do so, we should always have
two very certain tests by which to recognise that, for all that, they were not real men.
- The first is, that they could never use speech or other signs as we do when placing our
thoughts on record for the benefit of others. For we can easily understand a machine's
being constituted so that it can utter words, and even emit some responses to action
on it of a corporeal kind, which brings about a change in its organs; for instance, if it
is touched in a particular part it may ask what we wish to say to it; if in another part
it may exclaim that it is being hurt, and so on. But it never happens that it arranges
its speech in various ways, in order to reply appropriately to everything that may be
said in its presence, as even the lowest type of man can do.

- And the second difference is, that although machines can perform certain things as well as or perhaps better than any of us can do, they infallibly fall short in others, by the which means we may discover that they did not act from knowledge, but only from the disposition of their organs. For while reason is a universal instrument which can serve for all contingencies, these organs have need of some special adaptation for every particular action. From this it follows that it is morally impossible that there should be sufficient diversity in any machine to allow it to act in all the events of life in the same way as our reason causes us to act.